

YITP, Kyoto University, June 2026

Supertranslations as Soft Dressings

Donal O'Connell
Higgs Centre
University of Edinburgh

With Asaad Elkhidir
& Radu Roiban
2408.15961 and in preparation



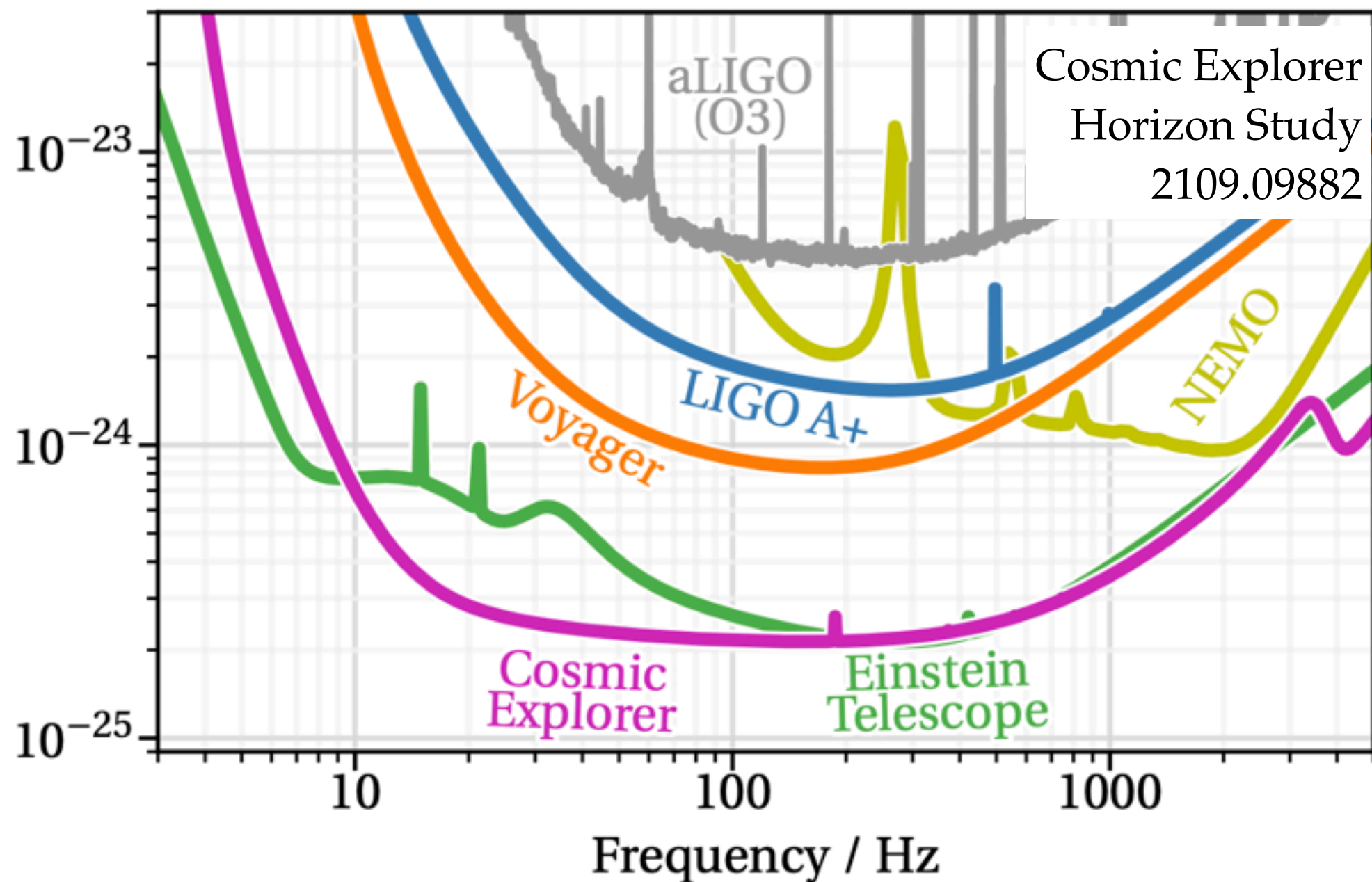
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Motivation

Quest for precision



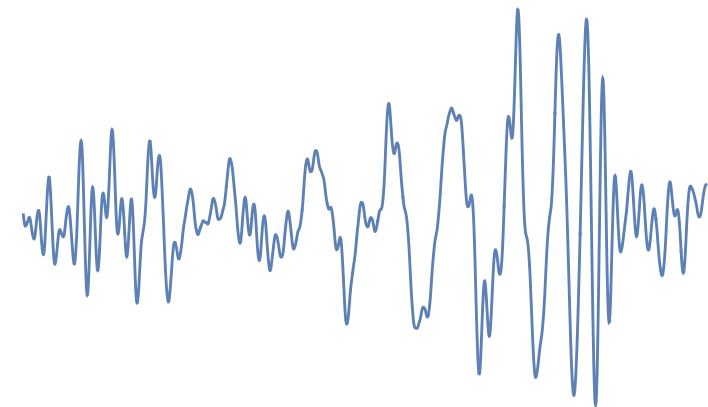
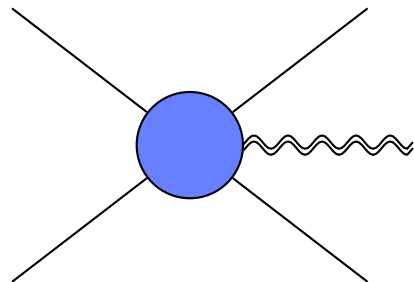
Motivation

Learn about field theory



Thibault's talk

Fruitful dialogue



Waveform $\neq$ cross-section

IR / long distance properties?

Outline

1. Waveforms
2. Large gauge transformations and “frames”
3. Single particle states
4. Supertranslations
5. Discussion

Waveforms

Waveforms

→ Fei's talk

$$\begin{aligned} \text{waveform}(t) &= \text{[peak waveform]} \\ &= \frac{1}{\text{distance}} \int \text{[5-point amplitude diagram]} + \dots \end{aligned}$$

5 point amplitude

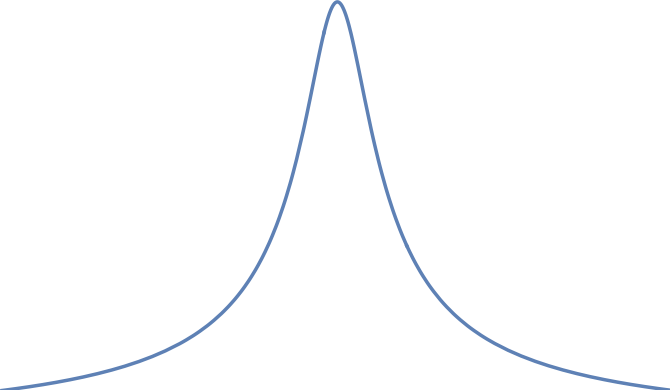
Classical point particle approximation (corrections at order G^7)

Kosower, Maybee & DOC "KMOC"

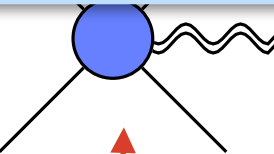
Cristofoli, Gonzo, Kosower & DOC

Waveforms

→ Fei's talk

waveform(t) = 

Useful: transfer precision information to bound case

= $\frac{1}{\text{distance}}$  + ...

5 point amplitude

Classical point particle approximation (corrections at order G^7)

Kosower, Maybee & DOC "KMOC"

Cristofoli, Gonzo, Kosower & DOC

Waveforms

Waveform: measuring metric change $g_{\mu\nu} - \eta_{\mu\nu} = h_{\mu\nu}$

QFT: observable is *expectation* of operator

$$h_{\mu\nu}(x) = \langle \psi | \mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) | \psi \rangle$$



Graviton quantum field

Waveforms

Waveform: measuring metric change $g_{\mu\nu} - \eta_{\mu\nu} = h_{\mu\nu}$

QFT: observable is *expectation* of operator

$$h_{\mu\nu}(x) = \langle \psi | \mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) | \psi \rangle$$

$$\mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) = \int \boxed{\mathrm{d}\Phi(k)} \varepsilon_{\mu}^{\eta}(k) \varepsilon_{\nu}^{\eta}(k) a_{\eta\eta}(k) e^{-ik \cdot x} + \text{h.c.}$$

Integral over physical momenta

$k^2 = 0$ “on-shell”

Waveforms

Waveform: measuring metric change $g_{\mu\nu} - \eta_{\mu\nu} = h_{\mu\nu}$

QFT: observable is *expectation* of operator

$$h_{\mu\nu}(x) = \langle \psi | \mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) | \psi \rangle$$

Graviton polarization tensor: helicity η

$$\mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) = \int d\Phi(k) \boxed{\varepsilon_{\mu}^{\eta}(k) \varepsilon_{\nu}^{\eta}(k)} a_{\eta\eta}(k) e^{-ik \cdot x} + \text{h.c.}$$

Waveforms

Waveform: measuring metric change $g_{\mu\nu} - \eta_{\mu\nu} = h_{\mu\nu}$

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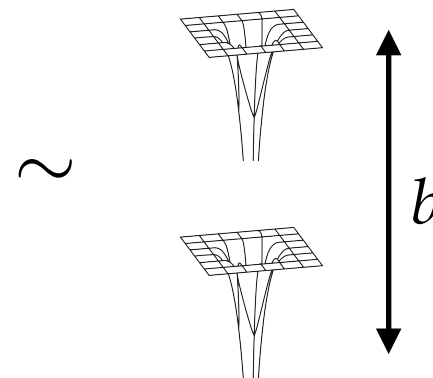
Graviton ladder
operator
helicity η

Waveforms

Initial state in classical approximation:

- ☑ Approximately localised
- ☑ Well-defined momentum

$$|\psi\rangle = \int d\Phi(p_1, p_2) \phi(p_1) \phi(p_2) e^{ip_1 \cdot b} |p_1, p_2\rangle \sim \int \Lambda \Lambda e^{ip_1 \cdot b} |p_1 p_2\rangle$$

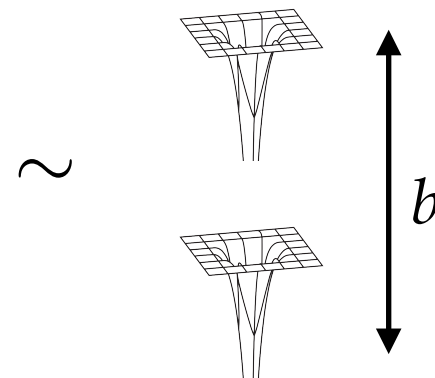


Waveforms

Initial state in classical approximation:

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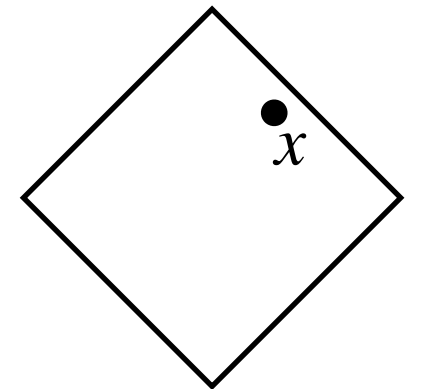


Note: no gravitons in initial state $a_{\eta\eta}(k) |\psi\rangle = 0$

Waveforms

Waveform: *future* expectation of metric operator

Time evolution operator: S matrix



$$\text{waveform} \equiv \langle \psi | S^\dagger \mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) S | \psi \rangle$$

Final state
Amplitudes!

Dominant term at large distances
(integral of Ψ_4)

$$|\psi\rangle \sim \int \mathcal{L} \mathcal{L} e^{ip_1 \cdot b} |p_1 p_2\rangle$$

Sets classical initial conditions

Kosower, Maybee & DOC “KMOC”

Cristofoli, Gonzo, Kosower & DOC

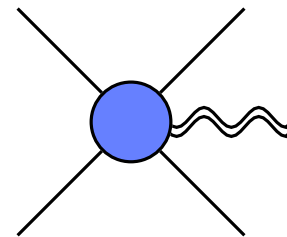
Waveforms

Waveform: *future* expectation of metric operator

$$\text{waveform} = \int d\Phi(k) [\varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-ik \cdot x} \langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle + \text{c.c.}]$$

$$= i \int d\Phi(k) \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-ik \cdot x} \langle \psi | a_{\eta\eta}(k) T | \psi \rangle + \text{c.c.} \quad @ \text{ LO}$$

5 point amplitude



Fei's talk

Waveforms

One oddity: *past* expectation of metric vanishes

$$\langle \psi | \mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) | \psi \rangle = \int d\Phi(k) e^{-ik \cdot x} \varepsilon_{\eta}^{\mu} \varepsilon_{\eta}^{\nu} \langle \psi | a_{\eta\eta}(k) | \psi \rangle + \text{c.c.} = 0$$



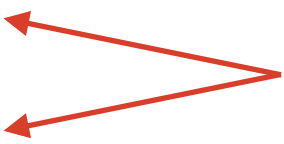
No gravitons in initial state

Should we be worried?

Large Gauge Transformations & “Frames”

Frames

QFT creation operators

$$\begin{aligned} |k, ++\rangle &= a_{++}^\dagger(k) |0\rangle \\ |k, --\rangle &= a_{--}^\dagger(k) |0\rangle \end{aligned}$$


Two states
Propagating fluctuations

Formalism designed to compute radiative “angular” components

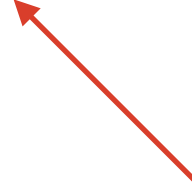
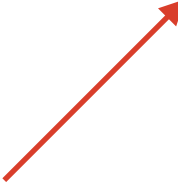
Frames

“Angular” components in gravity: Bondi shear

$$ds^2 = g_{uu} du^2 + 2g_{ur} du dr + 2g_{uA} du d\theta^A + r^2 \left(\Omega_{AB} + \frac{c_{AB}}{r} \right) d\theta^A d\theta^B$$

Angles θ^A 

Shear 

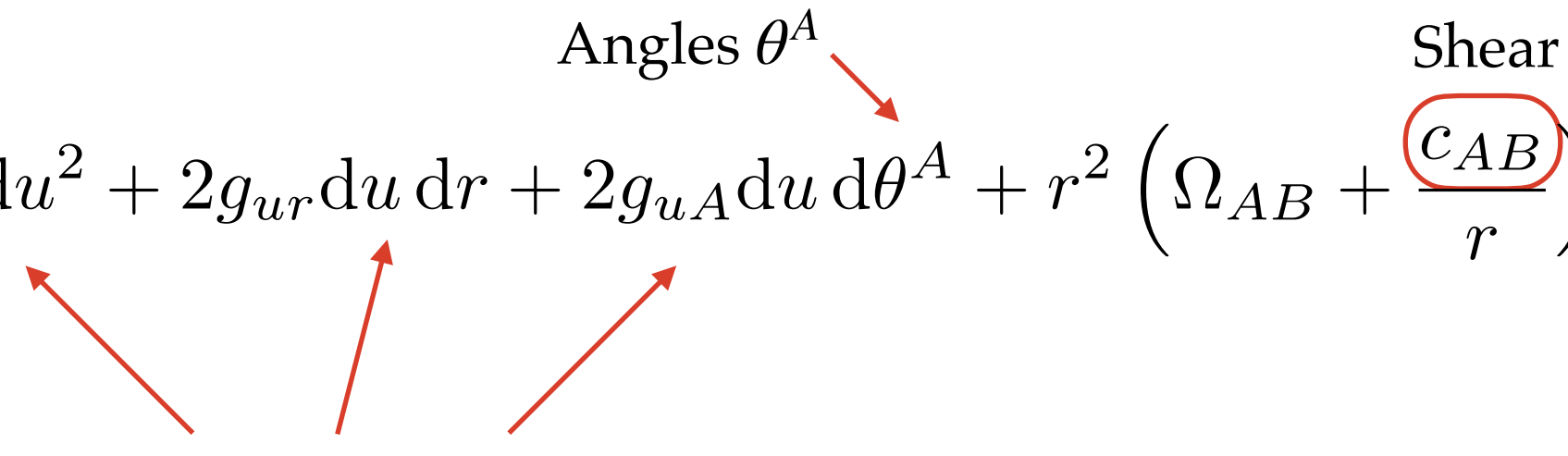
$$g_{rr} = g_{rA} = 0$$

Frames

“Angular” components in gravity: Bondi shear

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$g_{rr} = g_{rA} = 0$



Angles θ^A

Shear

Always available

Does metric of boosted Schwarzschild have zero shear?

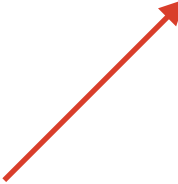
Frames

“Angular” components in gravity: Bondi shear

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Angles θ^A 

Shear 

$$g_{rr} = g_{rA} = 0$$

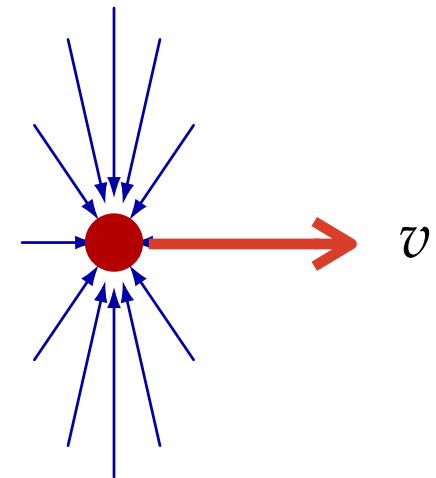
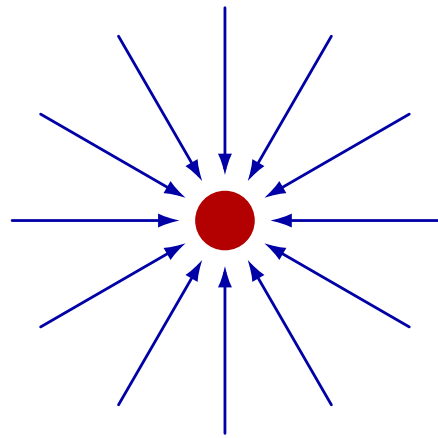
Always available

Which Schwarzschild?

Does metric of boosted Schwarzschild have zero shear?

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



Kerr Schild “frame”

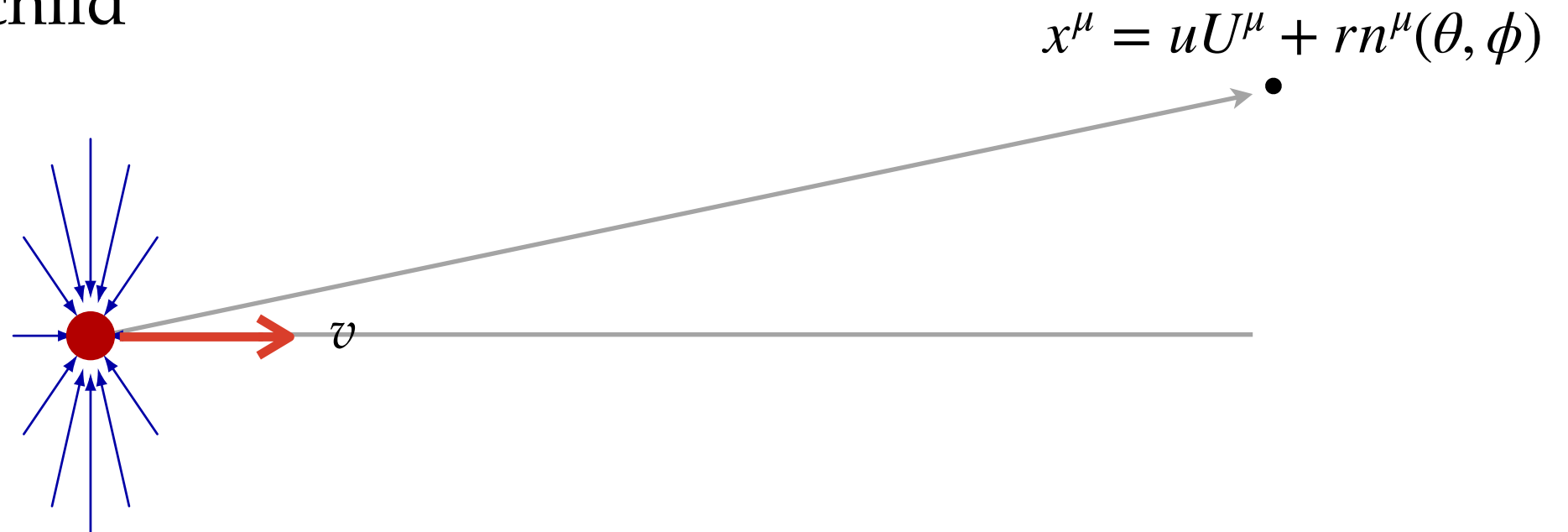
$$T = v \cdot x$$

$$R^2 = (v \cdot x)^2 - x^2$$

$$ds^2 = ds_0^2 - \frac{2GM}{R} d(T - R)^2$$

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



Kerr Schild “frame”

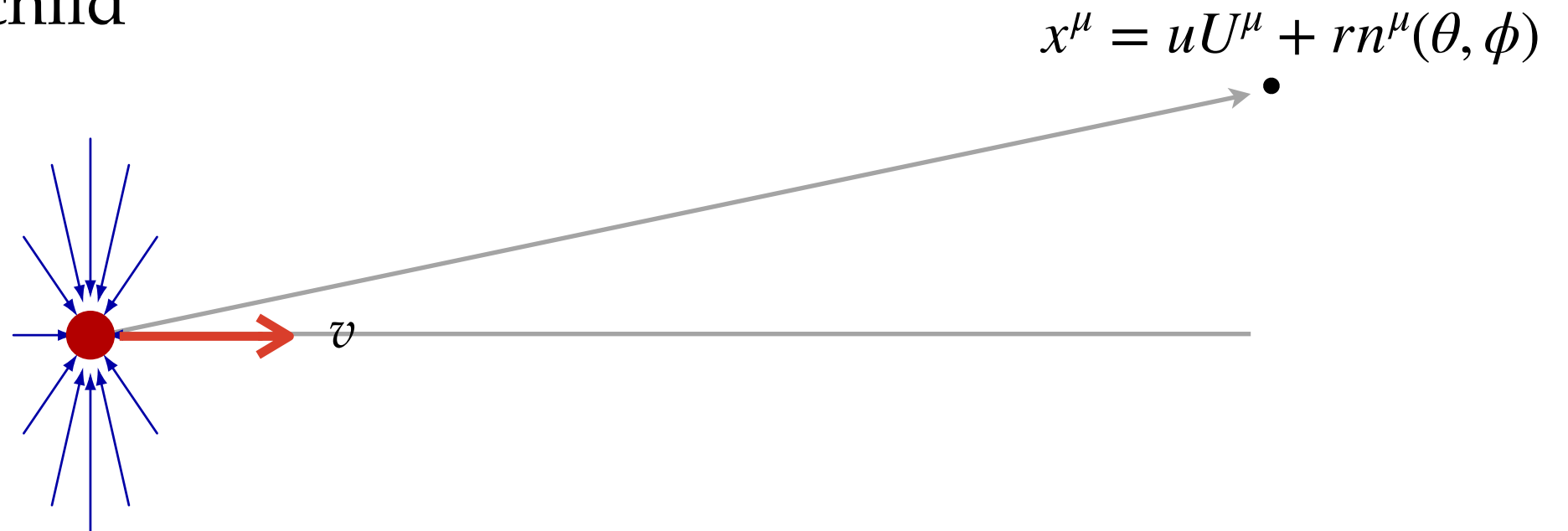
$$ds^2 = ds_0^2 - \frac{2GM}{R} d(T - R)^2$$

Two red curved arrows point from the terms T and R in the metric to their definitions:

$$T = v \cdot x$$
$$R^2 = (v \cdot x)^2 - x^2$$

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



Kerr Schild “frame”

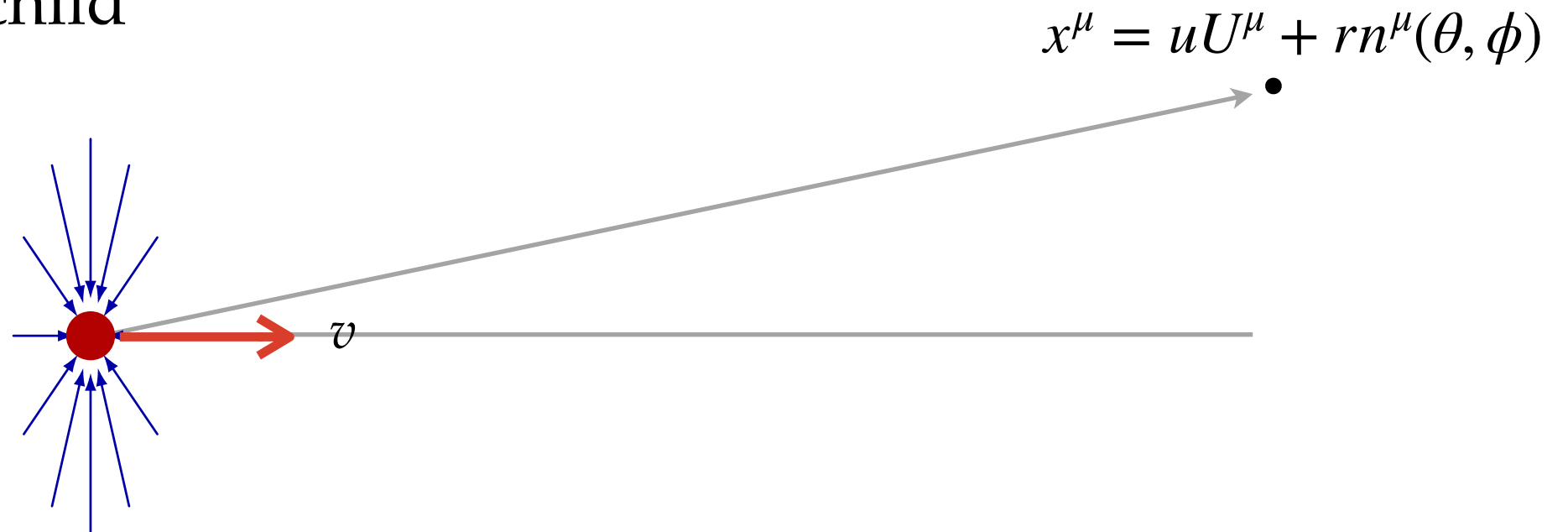
$$T = v \cdot x \rightarrow r(v \cdot n)$$

$$R^2 = (v \cdot x)^2 - x^2 \rightarrow r^2(v \cdot n)^2$$

$$ds^2 = ds_0^2 - \frac{2GM}{R} d(T - R)^2$$

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



Kerr Schild “frame”

$$T = v \cdot x \rightarrow r(v \cdot n)$$

$$R^2 = (v \cdot x)^2 - x^2 \rightarrow r^2(v \cdot n)^2$$

$$ds^2 = ds_0^2 - \frac{2GM}{R} d(T - R)^2 \rightarrow ds_0^2 - \frac{2GM}{r(v \cdot n)^3} (du^2 + \mathcal{O}(1/r^2))$$

Poisson & Bonga

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



Kerr Schild “frame”

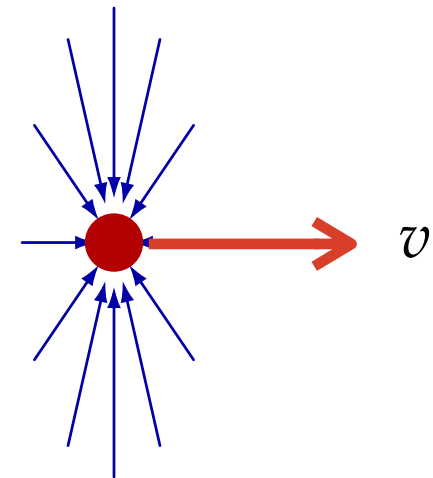
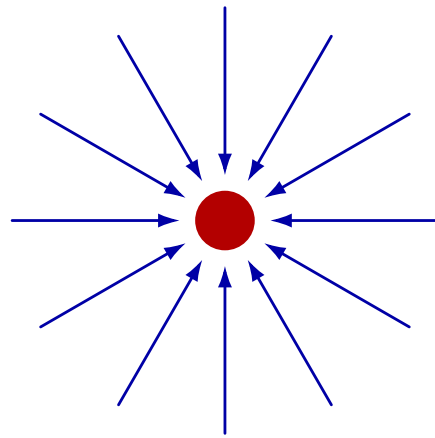
$$ds^2 = du^2 \left(1 - \frac{2GM}{r(v \cdot n)^3} \right) + 2du \, dr + r^2 \left(\Omega_{AB} + \frac{0}{r} \right) d\theta^A d\theta^B + \dots$$

Automatically Bondi

Poisson & Bonga

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



Kerr Schild “frame”

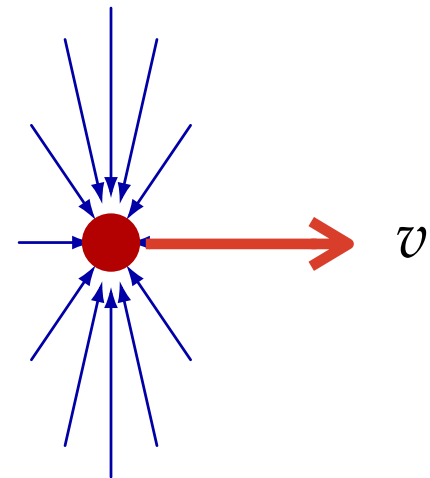
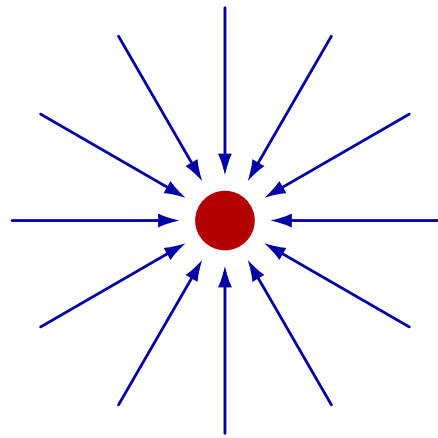
No shear — persists for 2 BHs

$$ds^2 = du^2 \left(1 - \frac{2GM}{r(v \cdot n)^3} \right) + 2du \, dr + r^2 \left(\Omega_{AB} + \boxed{\frac{0}{r}} \right) d\theta^A d\theta^B + \dots$$

Poisson & Bonga

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild

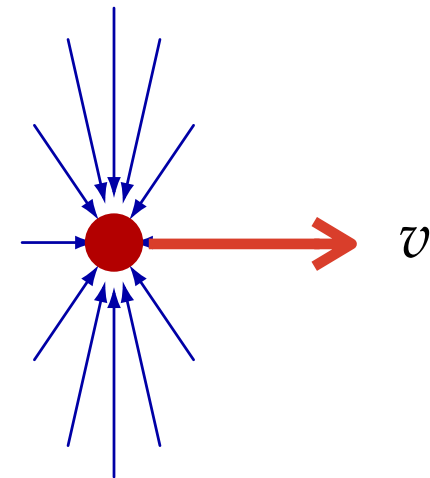
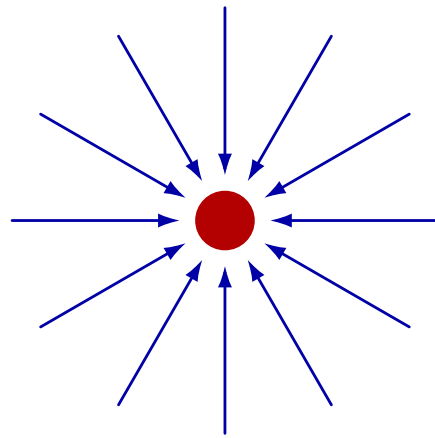


De Donder “frame”

$$ds^2 = ds_0^2 - \frac{4GM}{R} \left(v_\mu v_\nu - \frac{1}{2} \eta_{\mu\nu} \right) dx^\mu dx^\nu + \dots$$

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



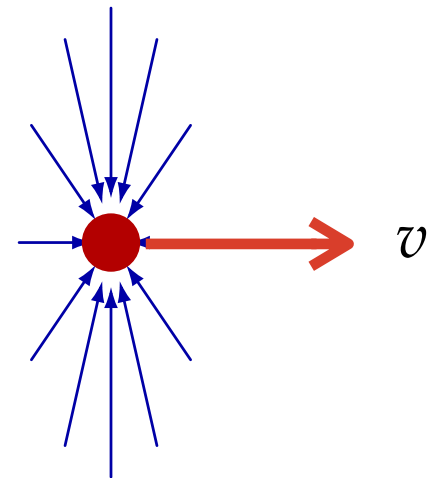
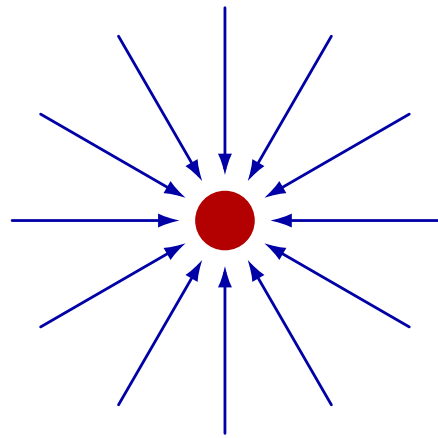
De Donder “frame”

$$ds^2 \rightarrow ds_0^2 - \frac{4GM}{r n \cdot v} \left((n \cdot v dr + r v \cdot dn)^2 - \frac{1}{2} r^2 \Omega_{AB} d\theta^A d\theta^B + \dots \right)$$

Not Bondi!

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild

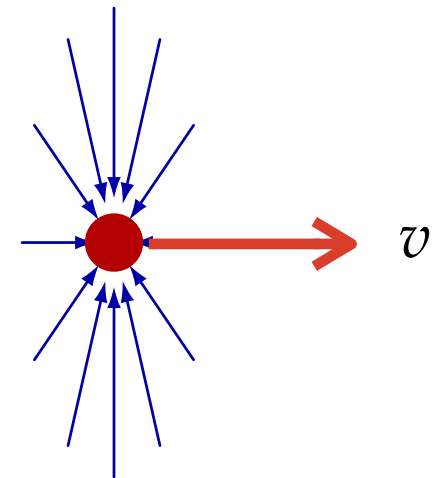
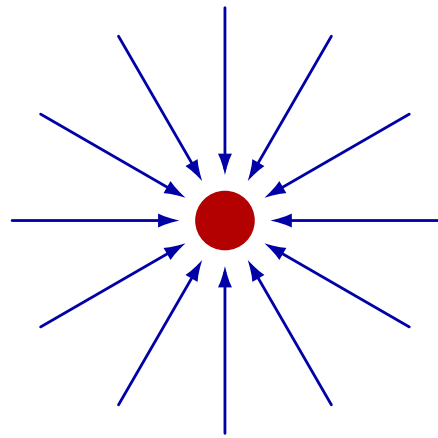


De Donder $\rightarrow$ Kerr Schild coords:

$$T \rightarrow T + 2GM \log R$$

Frames

Boosted Schwarzschild



De Donder $\rightarrow$ Kerr Schild coords:

$$\delta u = \sum_i 2GM_i n \cdot v_i \log n \cdot v_i + \text{const}$$

“Veneziano-Vilkovisky supertranslation”

Frames

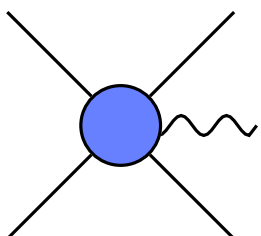
So naive amplitudes approach: Kerr-Schild gauge choice

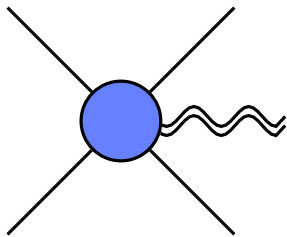
Kerr-Schild is canonical:

- ❖ Canonical BMS frame (zero shear)
- ❖ Canonical in QFT (simplest choice of ladder operators)

Frames

So naive amplitudes approach: Kerr-Schild gauge choice

$$A_\mu(u) = \frac{1}{\text{distance}} \int \text{diagram} + \dots \rightarrow F_{\mu\nu}(u), \quad \text{invariant}$$


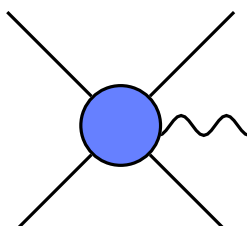
$$h_{\mu\nu}(u) = \frac{1}{\text{distance}} \int \text{diagram} + \dots \rightarrow R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}(u), \quad \text{not invariant}$$


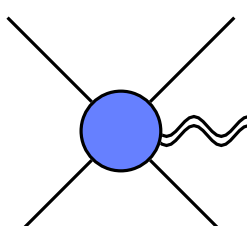

$$u \rightarrow u + 2Gm \, n \cdot v \log n \cdot v$$

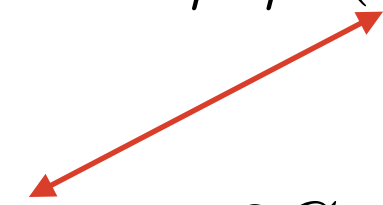
 Thibault's talk

Frames

So naive amplitudes approach: Kerr-Schild gauge choice

$$A_\mu(u) = \frac{1}{\text{distance}} \int \text{diagram} + \dots \rightarrow F_{\mu\nu}(u), \quad \text{invariant}$$


$$h_{\mu\nu}(u) = \frac{1}{\text{distance}} \int \text{diagram} + \dots \rightarrow R_{\mu\nu\rho\sigma}(u), \quad \text{not invariant}$$


$$u \rightarrow u + 2Gm n \cdot v \log n \cdot v$$


No local gauge invariant observables:



Thibault's talk

$$\psi_4(u) \rightarrow \psi_4(u + F(n))$$

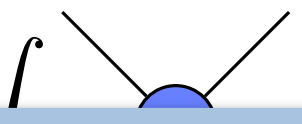
Bini, Damour, Geralico; Georgoudis, Heissenberg, Russo

Frames

So naive amplitudes approach: Kerr-Schild gauge choice

$A_\mu(u)$

 $h_{\mu\nu}(u)$



1. How does this manifest at GW observatories?

2. What is the right “frame” = large gauge choice?

3. How can we adjust frame in QFT approach?

variant

$$u \rightarrow u + 2Gm n \cdot v \log n \cdot v$$

No local gauge invariant observables:



Thibault's talk

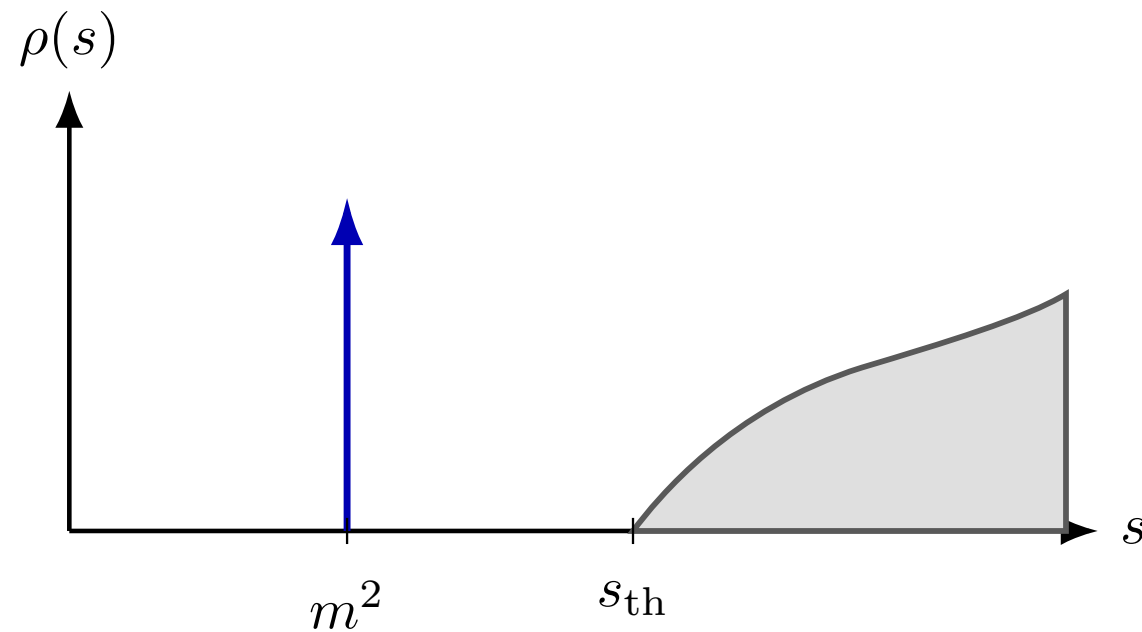
$$\psi_4(u) \rightarrow \psi_4(u + F(n))$$

Bini, Damour, Geralico; Georgoudis, Heissenberg, Russo

Single-Particle States

Single-Particle States

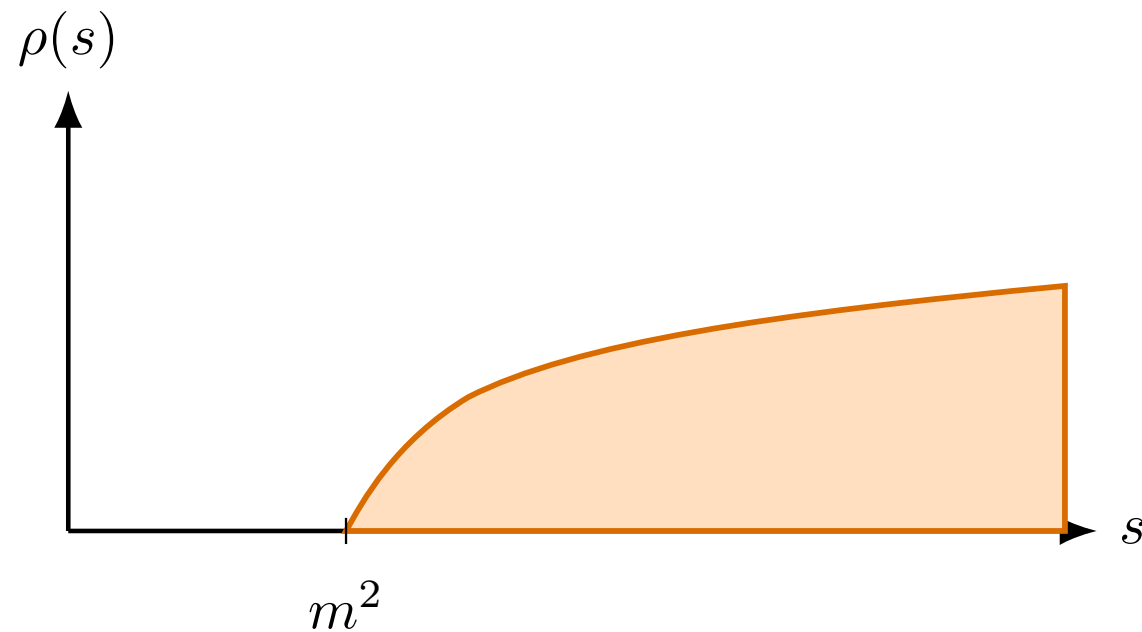
Gapped theory: isolated pole in spectral density



Massive pole well defined

Single-Particle States

No mass gap theory: no isolated pole



Massive pole *not* well defined

Single-Particle States

Definition of single particle state is ambiguous

Electromagnetic case
Simpler

$$|p\rangle \rightarrow \mathcal{O}(a_{\eta}^{\dagger})|p\rangle$$

Creates photon “cloud”

Single-Particle States

Definition of single particle state is ambiguous

Electromagnetic case
Simpler


$$|p\rangle \rightarrow \mathcal{O}(a_\eta^\dagger) |p\rangle$$

Momentum of particle invariant

$$\mathbb{P}_{\text{tot}}^\mu |p\rangle = \mathbb{P}_{\text{tot}}^\mu \mathcal{O}(a_\eta^\dagger) |p\rangle$$

Cloud of *infrared* photons

Idealisation: photon momenta zero

Single-Particle States

Related idealisation

$$\text{waveform} = \int d\Phi(k) \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-ik \cdot x} \langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle + \text{c.c.}$$

Radius r is very large: use stationary phase

$$\text{waveform} \simeq \frac{-i}{4\pi r} \int d\omega \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-i\omega u} \langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle \Big|_{\substack{k=\omega n \\ x^\mu = r n^\mu}} + \text{c.c.}$$

Single-Particle States

$$\text{waveform} \simeq \frac{-i}{4\pi r} \int d\omega \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-i\omega u} \langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle \Big|_{k=\omega n} + \text{c.c.}$$

Justified provided $r\omega \gg 1$

Single-Particle States

$$\text{waveform} \simeq \frac{-i}{4\pi r} \int d\omega \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-i\omega u} \langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle \Big|_{k=\omega n} + \text{c.c.}$$

Justified provided $r\omega \gg 1$

But...

$$\Delta h = h(\infty) - h(-\infty) = -i \int d\omega \omega \delta(\omega) \tilde{h}(\omega) \neq 0$$

“Memory”: waveform *must* include arbitrarily low frequencies

Idealisation: $1/r = 0$

Single-Particle States

Consider dressing with classical meaning

$$|p\rangle \rightarrow |p, f\rangle = e^{iQ_s[f]} |p\rangle$$

Infrared photons

$$Q_s[f] = \int d\Phi(k) \delta(\omega) (f_\eta(n) a_\eta^\dagger(\omega, n) + \text{h.c.})$$

$k^\mu = \omega n^\mu$ Defined by spin-weight ± 1 function

Larger class of localised, classical particle

$$|\psi\rangle = \int d\Phi(p) \phi(p) |p, f\rangle$$

Single-Particle States

So what's changed?

1. Initial EM field has expectation value

$$\langle \psi | A_\mu(x) | \psi \rangle = A_\mu(x) = \frac{1}{r} \sum_{\eta} \left(\varepsilon_{\mu}^{\eta} f_{\eta}(n) + \varepsilon_{\mu}^{\eta*} f_{\eta}^*(n) \right)$$

Spin-weight ± 1



Single-Particle States

So what's changed?

1. Initial EM field has expectation value

$$\langle \psi | \mathbb{A}_\mu(x) | \psi \rangle = A_\mu(x) = \frac{1}{r} \sum_{\eta} \left(\varepsilon_{\mu}^{\eta} f_{\eta}(n) + \varepsilon_{\mu}^{\eta*} f_{\eta}^*(n) \right)$$

 Spin-weight ± 1

Observer velocity U^μ , gauge choice $\varepsilon^\eta(n) \cdot U = 0 \Rightarrow \vec{\partial} = \varepsilon^+(n) \cdot \partial$

$$f_{\eta}(n) = \varepsilon^{\eta*} \cdot \partial F(n)$$

Single-Particle States

So what's changed?

1. Initial EM field has expectation value

Assume $F(n)$ is real

$$\langle \psi | \mathbb{A}_\mu(x) | \psi \rangle = A_\mu(x) = \frac{1}{r} \sum_\eta \left(\varepsilon_\mu^\eta \varepsilon^{\eta*} \cdot \partial F(n) + \varepsilon_\mu^{\eta*} \varepsilon^\eta \cdot \partial F^*(n) \right)$$


Observer coordinates $x^\mu = uU^\mu + rn^\mu$

$$A \cdot dx = dn^\mu \partial_\mu F(n) = \boxed{dF(n)}$$

Pure gauge

Large gauge transformation

Single-Particle States

So what's changed?

2. Spectral density in Källén-Lehmann representation changes

$$i\Delta_F(p) = \int ds \frac{\rho(s)}{p^2 - s + i\epsilon}$$

$$\rho(s) \rightarrow \rho_f(s)$$

Single-Particle States

Gravitational case

$$Q_s[f] = \int d\Phi(k) \delta(\omega) (f_{\eta\eta}(n) a_{\eta\eta}^\dagger(\omega, n) + \text{h.c.})$$

Spin-weight ± 2

$$f_{\eta\eta}(n) = \varepsilon_\eta^{*\mu} \varepsilon_\eta^{*\nu} \nabla_\mu \nabla_\nu F(n)$$

Expectation value, real F

$$\begin{aligned} h_{\mu\nu} dx^\mu dx^\nu &= \langle \psi | \mathbb{h}_{\mu\nu}(x) | \psi \rangle dx^\mu dx^\nu \\ &= r d\theta^A d\theta^B (2\nabla_A \nabla_B - \Omega_{AB} \nabla^2) F(n) \end{aligned}$$

BMS supertranslation $u \rightarrow u + F(n)$

Single-Particle States

Coherent state IR dressings:

- ❖ If real, generate pure gauge field expectations
- ❖ If imaginary: dual gauge transform (magnetic)

Classically associated with $u \rightarrow u + F(n)$

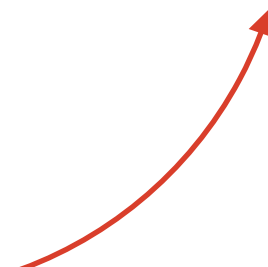
How does this emerge in the QFT approach?

Supertranslations

Supertranslations

$$\text{waveform} \simeq \frac{-i}{4\pi r} \int d\omega \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-i\omega u} \boxed{\langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle} \Big|_{k=\omega n} + \text{c.c.}$$

All the time
dependence



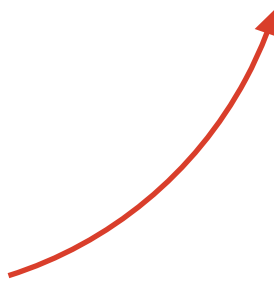
Expectation value to compute
Sensitive to dressing



Supertranslations

$$\text{waveform} \simeq \frac{-i}{4\pi r} \int d\omega \varepsilon^\eta \varepsilon^\eta e^{-i\omega u} \boxed{\langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle} \Big|_{k=\omega n} + \text{c.c.}$$

All the time
dependence



Expectation value to compute
Sensitive to dressing



Focus on expectation:

$$\langle \psi | S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S | \psi \rangle = \int \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s[f]} S^\dagger a_{\eta\eta}(k) S e^{iQ_s[f]} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

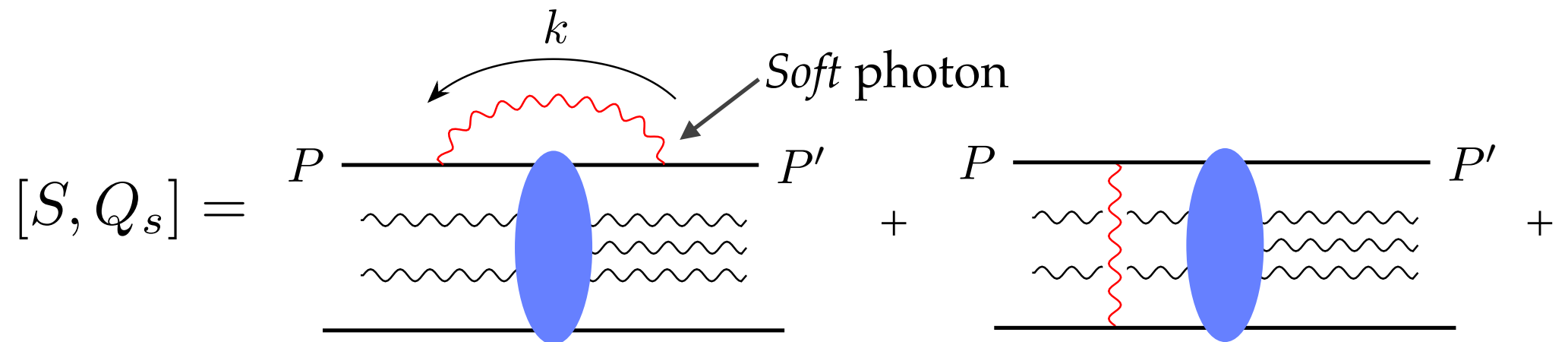
Short story: interactions same up to phase $e^{-i\omega F(n)}$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

E&M:



$$= -[S, Q_{h,M}] \quad Q_{h,M} \sim \sum_i Q_{h,i} A_i^\dagger A_i$$

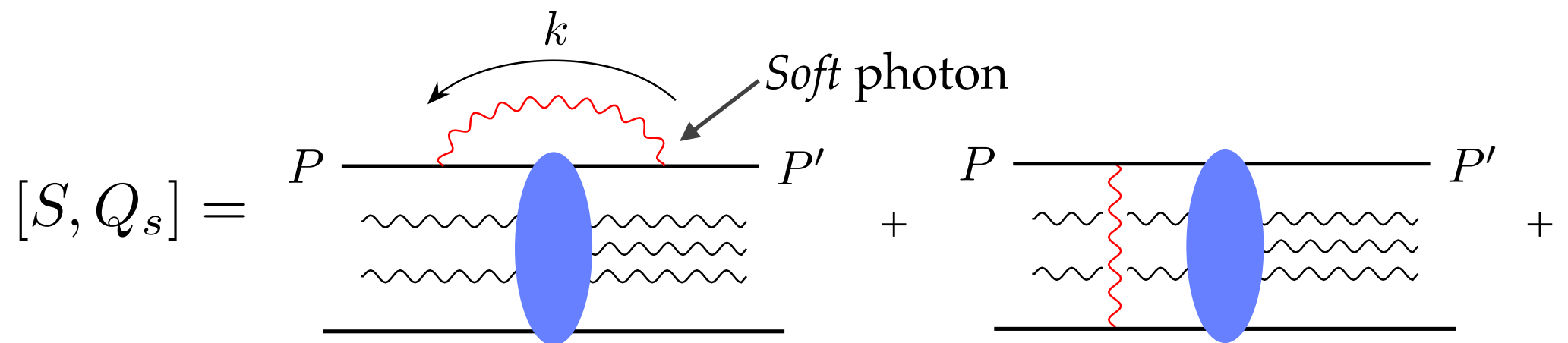
$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-i(Q_s + Q_h)} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{i(Q_s + Q_h)} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

E&M:



$$= -[S, Q_{h,M}] \quad Q_{h,M} \sim \sum_i Q_{h,i} A_i^\dagger A_i$$

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger e^{-i(Q_s + Q_h)} a(k) e^{i(Q_s + Q_h)} S | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

E&M:

$$e^{-iQ_s} a(k) e^{iQ_s} = a(k) + \text{gauge}$$

So dressed EM waveform = “canonical” waveform + large gauge

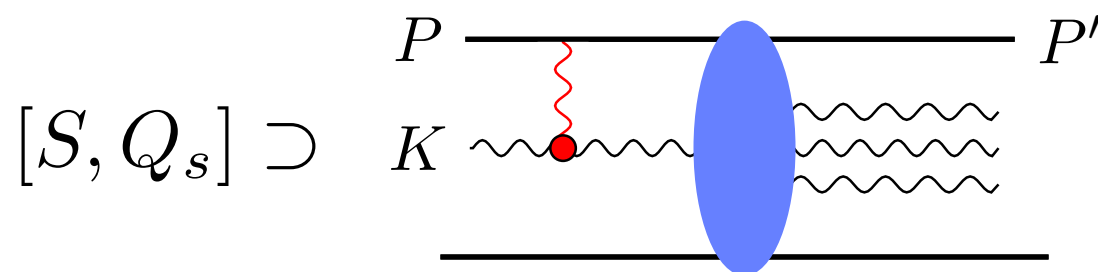
$$A'^\mu = A^\mu_{\text{canonical}} + \partial^\mu F(n)$$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

In GR, dressing involves $\delta^2 F(n)$



Loop integrals
remove δ !

$$Q_h = - \int F(n) a^\dagger(\omega n) a(\omega n) + Q_{h,i}$$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

In GR, dressing involves $\partial^2 F(n)$

$$Q_h = - \int F(n) a^\dagger(\omega n) a(\omega n) + Q_{h,i}$$

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-i(Q_s + Q_h)} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{i(Q_s + Q_h)} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

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$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger e^{-i(Q_s + Q_h)} a(k) e^{i(Q_s + Q_h)} S | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

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Supertranslations

Dressed expectation value

$$\langle p'_1 p'_2 | S^\dagger a(k) S | p_1 p_2 \rangle \rightarrow \langle p'_1 p'_2 | e^{-iQ_s} S^\dagger a(k) S e^{iQ_s} | p_1 p_2 \rangle$$

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$$Q_h = - \int F(n) a^\dagger(\omega n) a(\omega n) + Q_{h,i}$$

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Combines with $e^{-i\omega u}$ to get $u \rightarrow u + F(n)$

Conclusion

One-one correspondence :

- ❖ BMS supertranslations of asymptotically flat spacetimes with N compact objects
- ❖ Real low-energy coherent dressings of states with N massive particles

Amplitudes setup: Kerr-Schild frame

Dressing also leads to shift energy-dependent shift of impact parameter